

Friction-maxxing: Is convenience
weakening our brains?

“阻力最大化”：便捷的生活是否正在削弱我们的
思考能力？

词汇: *technology* 科技

- 1 We all know the feeling. You have a big, difficult task to complete, but your phone is on the desk next to you, teasing you with endless distraction opportunities. What's happening on social media? What's going on in the news? Who's messaging me? This constant **bombardment** of information through our screens, coupled with a tendency to **outsource** even basic tasks to technology, might be making us unhappier and more resistant to difficult tasks. Is 'friction-maxxing' the answer?
- 2 Humans like to choose the **path of least resistance** to conserve energy, but actually, tasks that require more effort often feel more **meaningful**. Friction-maxxing is a new trend which aims to rebuild our **tolerance** for **inconvenience**. In a basic sense, this involves adding more 'friction' to tasks so that they require more time, effort or patience, which, in theory, leads to greater feelings of satisfaction and reward. A series of experiments carried out in 2012 by researchers Norton, Mochon and Ariely found that when people built their own furniture, they had a greater sense of their own **competence** and pride in their creations.
- 3 Our brains operate on a 'use it or lose it' principle, says Gloria Mark, psychologist and author of book 'Attention Span'. To keep new brain **neurons** alive, we must keep using them by continuing to do effortful tasks. If we rely too much on technology, we risk weakening our mental skills. Many of us use GPS apps to direct us around a city, but overusing these apps appears to be reducing our natural **sense of direction**, according to a study published in the Scientific Reports journal by Dahmani and Bohbot. On the other hand, studies show that cognitively **stimulating** activities which require more patience, like reading, doing puzzles and learning an instrument, can preserve our brain function as we age.

- 4 Some are unconvinced by the 'friction-maxxing' trend. Psychologist and author of 'The Distracted Mind', Larry Rosen, believes it's too hard to resist the convenience technology provides. The trend doesn't hurt, says Gloria Mark. "If people are putting in effort, it makes them more **intentional** and thoughtful." Perhaps by taking the easy route, we're **missing out on** some of life's enjoyment.

测验与练习

一、将标题和段落配对。

Paragraph 1 _____

Paragraph 2 _____

Paragraph 3 _____

Paragraph 4 _____

- a. More effortful tasks are more rewarding
- b. Technology increases productivity
- c. The effects of screens on our emotional intelligence
- d. How technology distracts us
- e. Doubts about friction-maxxing
- f. Relying on technology weakens the brain

二、根据文章内容选出正确的选项。

- 1. Humans prefer to choose the most convenient way of doing something.
 - a. True
 - b. False
 - c. Not given
- 2. Friction-maxxing is about avoiding inconvenience.
 - a. True
 - b. False
 - c. Not given
- 3. Which is the best description of the 'use it or lose it' principle?
 - a. Keep using phone apps or they will be deleted.
 - b. Continue doing something until you lose attention.
 - c. Continue doing something to strengthen your brain neurons.

4. Activities like reading and learning a musical instrument are examples of friction-maxxing.
 - a. True
 - b. False
 - c. Not given

5. Larry Rosen is a proponent of friction-maxxing.
 - a. True
 - b. False
 - c. Not given

三、用方框中的单词完成对本文的总结。

Humans have a preference for the **1)** _____, meaning we prefer convenience over effort. In the modern world, to avoid **2)** _____, we tend to **3)** _____ our problems to technology. However, this means tasks have become less **4)** _____ and we are less sure of our own **5)** _____. Friction-maxxing is a new trend to build our tolerance for doing difficult things.

miss out on	neurons	meaningful
inconvenience		outsource
competence		path of least resistance

（答案见词汇表后）

词汇表

bombardment	(信息、问题等的) 连珠炮似冲击
outsource	把...委托办理
path of least resistance	阻力最小的路径, 最省力的途径
meaningful	有意义的
tolerance	耐受力
inconvenience	不便, 麻烦
competence	能力, 胜任感
neuron	神经元, 神经细胞
sense of direction	方向感
stimulating	刺激的, 促进身体机能的
intentional	有意的, 有目的性的
miss out on (something)	错失..., 与...失之交臂

答案

一、将标题和段落配对。

Paragraph 1 **d) How technology distracts us**

Paragraph 2 **a) More effortful tasks are more rewarding**

Paragraph 3 **f) Relying on technology weakens the brain**

Paragraph 4 **e) Doubts about friction-maxxing**

二、根据文章内容选出正确的选项。

1. **a. True.** *Humans like to choose the **path of least resistance** to conserve energy...*
2. **b. False.** *Friction-maxxing is a new trend which aims to **rebuild our tolerance for inconvenience**.*
3. **c. To keep new brain **neurons alive**, we must **keep using them by continuing to do effortful tasks**.**
4. **a. True.** *[Friction-maxxing] involves adding more 'friction' to tasks so that they **require more time, effort or patience**... cognitively stimulating activities which **require more patience** like **reading**, doing puzzles and **learning an instrument**...*
5. **b. False.** *Some are **unconvinced** by the 'friction-maxxing' trend. Psychologist and author of 'The Distracted Mind', Larry Rosen, believes **it's too hard to resist the convenience technology provides**.*

三、用方框中的单词完成对本文的总结。

Humans have a preference for the **path of least resistance**, meaning we prefer convenience over effort. In the modern world, to avoid **inconvenience**, we tend to **outsource** our problems to technology. However, this means tasks have become less **meaningful** and we are less sure of our own **competence**. Friction-maxxing is a new trend to build our tolerance for doing difficult things.